

Aligning National Recruitment Levers with OECD Guidance: A Comparative Policy Analysis of Taiwan's Foreign English Teacher Program (TFETP)

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Abstract

Teacher attrition and persistent vacancies threaten instructional quality and equity across systems, yet prevailing guidance often lacks sufficient specificity for adoption. This study presents an implementation-oriented, desk-based comparative policy analysis of Taiwan's Foreign English Teacher Program (TFETP) to examine how recruitment and retention instruments are codified and how closely they accord with recent international recommendations. Publicly available TFETP contracts, program manuals, and ministerial guidance were systematically reviewed and extracted, then coded across six predefined dimensions: (1) compensation structure and progression; (2) performance-contingent bonuses; (3) relocation and settlement supports; (4) workload remuneration for additional instructional periods; (5) social insurance and worker protections; and (6) onboarding and domestic transport assistance. For each dimension, provisions were rated for alignment with international guidance (High/Partial/Low) and appraised for portability, operationalized as the minimal legal, fiscal, and administrative preconditions for adoption in other jurisdictions. A dual-pass intra-rater consistency check was used to enhance coding reliability.

Findings indicate substantial alignment on predictable salary progression, transparent annual performance bonuses, capped relocation reimbursements, explicit overtime compensation, and bundled insurance/onboarding supports—mechanisms that plausibly reduce entry frictions and stabilize early-tenure retention. By contrast, gaps are observed in the public reporting of implementation fidelity and retention outcomes, as well as in the formalization of structured induction/mentoring and targeted incentives for hard-to-staff subjects and regions. The study contributes three practice-ready artefacts: (a) a transparent TFETP–international policy matrix, (b) an alignment summary identifying strengths and blind spots, and (c) a portability checklist that translates high-level recommendations into adoptable clause language with enabling conditions. By specifying mechanisms and implementation prerequisites rather than enumerating generic categories, the analysis advances a replicable, cross-jurisdictional approach to teacher-workforce stabilization that can be undertaken without new primary data collection. The framework is intended to support ministries and districts in calibrating recruitment and retention packages to local constraints while remaining consistent with international evidence.

Keywords: teacher recruitment; retention; comparative policy analysis; policy portability; international alignment

I. Introduction

1.1 Background: Global Teacher Shortages and Policy Responses

Teacher shortages have become one of the most urgent and persistent challenges confronting education systems worldwide. The **UNESCO International Task Force on Teachers for Education 2030 (2024)** estimated that approximately **44 million new teachers** are required by 2030 to achieve universal primary and secondary education. Earlier projections placed this figure at nearly 69 million, illustrating the enduring gap between teacher supply and demand (UNESCO, 2023). This global shortfall is not simply a numerical deficit; it signals a deeper structural imbalance between the growing complexity of educational goals and the limited attractiveness of teaching as a lifelong profession.

Across the **OECD** member and partner countries, this imbalance has intensified. According to *Education at a Glance 2024*, the proportion of students whose principals reported teacher-staff shortages rose from 29 percent in 2015 to 46.7 percent in 2022 (OECD, 2024a). The crisis is particularly acute in **STEM**, special education, and early-childhood sectors, where attrition intersects with declining enrollments in teacher-education programs. In parallel, the **Asian Development Bank (2023)** found that throughout Asia-Pacific, teacher pipelines are constrained by aging workforces, stagnant wages, and limited professional-learning opportunities—factors that together exacerbate inequities in educational provision. These findings converge on a single point: global teacher shortages simultaneously threaten **education quality** and **educational equity**, since schools serving marginalized communities are most likely to face chronic vacancies and instability.

Because of this dual threat, teacher shortages must be understood through the twin lenses of **recruitment** and **retention**. Recruitment expands the pool of qualified candidates, but retention determines whether systems can maintain the continuity, experience, and institutional knowledge necessary for effective teaching. The **OECD (2024b)** emphasizes that policies narrowly focused on short-term recruitment drives—without addressing working conditions, autonomy, and professional identity—merely recycle the problem. Similarly, the **UNESCO**

Global Report on Teachers (2024) argues that sustained retention is essential for delivering equitable learning opportunities, noting that “solving shortages is not merely about numbers; it is about sustaining the conditions under which teachers can thrive” (p. 11). Thus, recruitment and retention form the moral and operational core of any credible strategy for achieving **Sustainable Development Goal 4**: inclusive, equitable, and quality education for all.

In response, governments worldwide have pursued a variety of policy measures, revealing a gradual evolution from reactive hiring toward **systemic professionalization**. Many systems continue to rely on **financial incentives**—including signing bonuses, rural-hardship allowances, and loan-forgiveness schemes—but their effectiveness depends heavily on accompanying reforms that enhance teachers’ professional lives. Evidence from the **OECD Education Policy Outlook (2024b)** and **ADB (2023)** points to several converging priorities:

1. Clear **career-progression pathways** that link advancement to professional mastery rather than tenure alone.
2. Comprehensive **mentoring and induction programs** that support novice teachers and mitigate early attrition.
3. Accessible, high-quality **continuous professional development (CPD)** aligned with curriculum innovation and digital transitions.
4. **Localized incentives** and flexible staffing policies responsive to rural, multilingual, or specialized contexts.

Taken together, these reforms reflect a paradigm shift from “filling vacancies” to **building sustainable professional ecosystems**. They also demonstrate that addressing shortages requires cross-sector coordination—linking education ministries, finance departments, and local governments—to balance fiscal responsibility with long-term workforce vitality.

These global dynamics find a distinct resonance in **Taiwan**, where demographic and policy transformations have reshaped the teacher-supply landscape. Like many developed systems, Taiwan faces an **aging teaching workforce**, with a significant proportion of teachers approaching retirement (Ho & Tsai, 2023). At the same time, the **Bilingual 2030 Policy**,

launched by the **National Development Council (NDC, 2021)**, has expanded demand for teachers capable of delivering English-medium or bilingual instruction across K–12 and higher education. The policy’s ambition—to position Taiwan as a bilingual nation by 2030—has generated unprecedented staffing pressures, especially in rural areas where English-qualified teachers are scarce.

To bridge this gap, the **Taiwan Foreign English Teacher Program (TFETP)** was created by the **Ministry of Education (MOE, 2024)** as a national recruitment mechanism for certified foreign English teachers and teaching assistants. TFETP aims to enrich language learning, support local co-teaching models, and advance the bilingual agenda. Yet, consistent with global evidence, **recruitment alone has not ensured retention**. Studies highlight continuing challenges such as high turnover, limited cultural orientation, and uneven regional placement (Graham & Yeh, 2023). Moreover, as **Hung et al. (2025)** show, successful bilingual implementation depends on sustained professional development for both domestic and foreign educators, ensuring pedagogical coherence rather than reliance on temporary staffing solutions.

Consequently, Taiwan’s bilingual initiative exemplifies how **global policy lessons meet national realities**. It encapsulates the transition from emergency recruitment toward integrated workforce planning—an evolution essential for maintaining educational equity amid demographic change and linguistic globalization. By aligning OECD and UNESCO principles with local innovation, Taiwan’s experience underscores that teacher-shortage solutions must be simultaneously **globally informed** and **locally grounded**.

In summary, the teacher-shortage crisis is a global challenge with local expressions. It intertwines structural, economic, and professional dimensions that demand coordinated action. International evidence shows that durable improvement hinges on three principles: (1) addressing both recruitment and retention as inseparable goals; (2) framing teacher policy within the broader pursuit of equity and quality; and (3) adapting global frameworks to local contexts through professional development and supportive working conditions. Taiwan’s current reforms—particularly its Bilingual 2030 Policy and TFETP—illustrate these imperatives in practice. They demonstrate how global insights can inform national strategies, providing a fertile

foundation for examining how recruitment, retention, and professionalization intersect in specific policy environments.

1.2 Policy Gap and Rationale

While international organizations such as the **OECD**, **UNESCO**, and the **World Bank** have produced extensive policy guidance on teacher recruitment and retention, most recommendations remain **normative or aspirational** rather than operational. The OECD's *Education Policy Outlook 2024* calls for “coherent, system-wide teacher policies that balance attraction, development, and retention” (OECD, 2024b, p. 19), yet offers limited direction on how governments should translate such goals into administrable instruments. Similarly, the *World Bank Global Platform for Successful Teachers*(2023) outlines key dimensions—selection, preparation, support, and motivation—but stops short of specifying measurable indicators of implementation. Consequently, the **policy–practice gap** persists: governments adopt the rhetoric of teacher professionalization but often lack actionable frameworks to monitor whether interventions truly align with international standards.

This study addresses that gap by developing an **implementation-oriented comparative framework** to evaluate how Taiwan's *Foreign English Teacher Program* (TFETP) embodies or diverges from prevailing international guidance. Central to this inquiry are two analytical constructs: **policy alignment** and **policy portability**. *Policy alignment* refers to the degree to which national instruments—such as compensation structures, professional supports, or mobility incentives—reflect evidence-based recommendations from multilateral bodies. *Policy portability* concerns the feasibility of transferring those instruments across jurisdictions with minimal legal, fiscal, or administrative adaptation. Together, these constructs operationalize the often abstract principles found in OECD and World Bank reports, transforming them into evaluative criteria for concrete policy analysis.

By focusing on alignment and portability, the study moves beyond descriptive comparison to provide a replicable model for assessing **how international frameworks are domesticated**, particularly in middle-income, innovation-driven education systems such as Taiwan's.

1.3 Research Objectives and Questions

Building upon the background and rationale, the present study pursues three interrelated objectives:

1. To **evaluate the coherence** of TFETP’s recruitment and retention instruments against OECD and broader international guidance;
2. To **examine the transferability** of these instruments—identifying which policy levers demonstrate high potential for adoption in other contexts; and
3. To **identify implementation gaps** that constrain policy effectiveness and limit cross-system learning.

Correspondingly, the study is guided by the following research questions:

- **RQ1:** To what extent do TFETP instruments align with OECD and international teacher-policy recommendations?
- **RQ2:** Which policy levers within TFETP demonstrate high *portability*—that is, feasible replication across different national or subnational systems?
- **RQ3:** What *implementation gaps* hinder the program’s effectiveness and reduce its replicability within broader teacher-workforce reforms?

These questions collectively situate Taiwan’s TFETP within the wider global discourse on teacher-workforce stabilization, allowing the study to bridge international frameworks with national administrative practice.

1.4 Contribution and Structure of the Paper

This paper contributes to comparative education and teacher-policy scholarship in three principal ways.

First, it advances a **replicable analytical framework** for assessing *policy alignment* and

portability—translating abstract global guidance into empirically testable dimensions.

Second, it provides **evidence-informed insights** into how specific recruitment and retention levers—such as salary progression, relocation support, and professional development—function within an actual national initiative (TFETP).

Third, it demonstrates the **practical value of cross-system benchmarking**: by identifying which instruments are adaptable across contexts, the study offers policymakers a template for designing sustainable teacher-workforce reforms.

2. Literature Review (900–1000 words)

2. Literature Review

2.1 The Global Challenge of Teacher Recruitment and Retention

Teacher recruitment and retention have emerged as intertwined crises shaping the stability and quality of education systems worldwide. Both the **OECD (2024a)** and **UNESCO (2024)** warn that shortages are now chronic rather than cyclical, reflecting deep structural weaknesses in how teaching is organized, rewarded, and supported. Globally, these shortages are driven by four intersecting dimensions—**attrition, compensation, workload, and motivation**—each influencing the sustainability of the teacher workforce.

High rates of teacher attrition remain the most visible symptom of system-level stress. Across OECD economies, turnover is concentrated among early-career teachers, educators in low-income communities, and those in high-demand subject areas such as STEM (OECD, 2024a; Thompson-Lee et al., 2025). Comparative data from **TALIS 2018** show that roughly one in five teachers report plans to leave the profession within five years, citing poor working conditions and limited career prospects (OECD, 2019). **Ingersoll (2021)** reframes this trend as an *organizational* rather than individual failure: attrition arises less from personal inadequacy than from weak institutional support structures.

Workplace climate and leadership are central mediators. Teachers reporting collaborative cultures and participatory leadership are substantially more likely to stay (Wynn & Brown, 2008;

Gundlach, 2025). Conversely, rigid accountability regimes and limited decision-making autonomy accelerate burnout (Edisa & Mirdin, 2025). Thus, the first thread connecting the global evidence is that **attrition cannot be solved through recruitment alone**; it requires systemic reform of teachers' everyday work environments.

Closely tied to attrition are issues of compensation and perceived fairness. Teachers' salaries remain below those of comparably educated professionals—averaging only 76 percent of earnings for other tertiary-educated workers across OECD countries (OECD, 2024a). This persistent pay gap undermines the attractiveness of teaching and contributes to declining enrollment in teacher-education programs (Darling-Hammond, 2017). While **financial incentives**—including hardship allowances and performance bonuses—have become standard policy responses, their effects are uneven. Meta-analyses show that incentives may temporarily stabilize staffing in shortage subjects or rural areas but seldom sustain long-term commitment (Hoque, 2025; OECD, 2022).

Recent experiments with differentiated salary progression, such as the “**Golden Ticket**” model linking pay to mentoring and professional contributions (Liu & Li, 2025), suggest that compensation reforms are most effective when embedded within clear career frameworks. In this way, the salary issue connects directly to professional identity: teachers remain when remuneration signals recognition of expertise rather than mere compliance with workload demands.

Compensation alone, however, cannot offset the burdens of excessive workload. Teachers' weekly schedules are increasingly dominated by administrative tasks, data reporting, and student-welfare duties, leaving limited time for planning or reflection (OECD, 2022). In **TALIS 2018**, teachers reported spending nearly 20 percent of their work hours on non-instructional duties. High workload correlates with emotional exhaustion and declining instructional quality (Geiger & Pivovarova, 2018).

Professional development (PD) emerges here as a crucial balancing mechanism. Well-designed PD not only improves instructional skill but also strengthens professional networks that

buffer against burnout (Darling-Hammond, 2017; Ovenden-Hope et al., 2018). Evidence from **teacher residency** and **RETAIN** programs indicates that integrated induction and PD substantially improve early-career retention (Kwok et al., 2024). Hence, workload management and professional growth are mutually reinforcing: when teachers have time and support to learn, they are more likely to stay—linking human-resource policy directly to pedagogical renewal.

While extrinsic incentives can attract candidates, retention ultimately hinges on **intrinsic motivation**—teachers’ moral purpose, sense of efficacy, and relational satisfaction. Studies across diverse settings show that teachers who find meaning in student learning or social contribution exhibit greater resilience in adverse conditions (Ashiedu & Scott-Ladd, 2012; Wiboolyasarin et al., 2025). In contrast, systems emphasizing surveillance and test-score accountability erode intrinsic motivation and accelerate attrition (Ingersoll, 2021). Therefore, recruitment and retention policies must integrate both extrinsic supports and intrinsic cultivation, positioning teaching as a vocation grounded in professionalism and purpose.

This connection between motivation and professional identity extends the logic of the previous sections: salary and workload reforms succeed only when teachers perceive the profession as intellectually respected and socially valued. Darling-Hammond (2017) argues that high-performing systems—such as Finland, Singapore, and Japan—retain teachers precisely because they embed professional learning and autonomy within a culture of public trust.

In the **Asia-Pacific**, teacher-supply challenges mirror global trends yet manifest with distinctive regional features. Rapid educational expansion, uneven resource allocation, and linguistic diversity complicate staffing policies (Graham & Yeh, 2023). Rural and remote schools experience acute shortages due to geographic isolation and limited amenities (Mafora, 2013). The **Asian Development Bank (2023)** identifies inadequate housing and transportation as primary deterrents for rural placement, suggesting that localized extrinsic incentives—such as accommodation or travel subsidies—can yield measurable retention gains.

Nevertheless, regional reforms remain fragmented. Pilot programs addressing shortages often end when external funding ceases, illustrating what **Shaoan et al. (2024)** term *policy*

discontinuity. Furthermore, cultural expectations of seniority over merit inhibit differentiated pay and career mobility (Hulme, 2023). These factors underline that while global frameworks provide direction, **contextual adaptation** determines success—a point that leads directly to the present study’s focus on *policy alignment* and *portability*.

Taken together, international and regional evidence yields three coherent lessons. First, **teacher attrition is systemic**, rooted in organizational structures rather than individual shortcomings (Ingersoll, 2021). Second, **financial incentives must be embedded within comprehensive professional ecosystems** that include workload regulation and continuous learning (OECD, 2024b; Darling-Hammond, 2017). Third, **policy transfer requires contextual calibration**: strategies that thrive in OECD economies may falter in middle-income or multilingual systems without adaptation (ADB, 2023).

Despite these insights, a key analytical gap persists. Most comparative studies remain descriptive, cataloguing shortages without evaluating how national programs operationalize global recommendations. Few frameworks measure *policy alignment*—the extent to which domestic instruments reflect international evidence—or assess *policy portability*—how feasibly such instruments can be transferred across jurisdictions. Bridging this gap demands empirical tools that move beyond rhetoric toward evidence-based assessment.

This study addresses that need by examining **Taiwan’s Foreign English Teacher Program (TFETP)** through these dual lenses. Building on the literature synthesized above, it investigates how Taiwan’s teacher-recruitment and retention mechanisms align with OECD and regional guidance, and which elements demonstrate potential for adaptation elsewhere. In doing so, it transforms abstract international principles into a replicable analytic framework for **teacher-workforce stabilization** in policy and practice.

2.2 Policy Levers and Theoretical Models

This section synthesizes three globally recognized teacher policy frameworks—the **OECD Teacher Policy Framework** (OECD, 2020), the **UNESCO Teacher Task Force Recommendations** (UNESCO, 2023), and the **World Bank SABER-Teachers Framework**

(Vegas et al., 2013)—and situates them within comparative approaches from **the United Kingdom, Korea, Japan, and Singapore**. Together, these frameworks converge on six actionable policy levers: **compensation, bonuses, relocation supports, workload pay, insurance, and onboarding/induction**. These levers provide a structured lens for coding and evaluating the design coherence and portability of teacher recruitment and retention mechanisms across contexts.

2.2.1 Global Frameworks

1. OECD Teacher Policy Framework (2020).

OECD guidance emphasizes that effective teacher policies balance **professional autonomy, career structures, and financial attractiveness**. Core levers include competitive **base pay** and **salary progression**, transparent **performance incentives**, **deployment equity**, and **induction supports** for novice teachers (OECD, 2020; OECD, 2022). The framework calls for an integrated “policy ecosystem” in which compensation and professional learning reinforce one another across the career cycle. Our coding treats OECD recommendations as the benchmark for *policy coherence and fiscal transparency*.

2. UNESCO International Task Force on Teachers for Education 2030 (2023).

The UNESCO framework highlights teachers’ **rights, decent work conditions, and social protection** as prerequisites for sustainable recruitment and retention (UNESCO, 2023). It urges governments to ensure **fair remuneration, health and safety coverage, and induction programs** that promote teacher well-being and professional identity. The UNESCO model provides a *rights-based and equity-oriented foundation*, complementing the OECD’s performance-oriented lens.

3. World Bank SABER-Teachers Framework.

The World Bank’s *System Approach for Better Education Results (SABER)* evaluates teacher policies across eight domains, notably **compensation, workload management, incentives, and support for new teachers** (Vegas et al., 2013; Bruns & Luque, 2015). It differentiates between the *existence* of policy, its *implementation*, and its *enforceability*. Within this study,

SABER serves as an *audit-oriented instrument*—allowing systematic coding (High/Partial/Low) of TFETP provisions and cross-country comparability.

2.2.2 Comparative Approaches: UK, Korea, Japan, and Singapore

1. United Kingdom.

England's Department for Education (DfE) maintains a **national pay framework** with incremental **salary scales** and role-linked **Teaching and Learning Responsibility (TLR)** payments (DfE, 2023). **Recruitment and Retention Allowances (R&R)** incentivize teachers in shortage areas, while the **Early Career Framework (ECF)** (2021) institutionalizes structured **onboarding and mentoring**. These codified systems exemplify transparent linkage between duties, pay, and support.

2. Korea.

Korea's system features **competitive base salaries**, substantial **rural and remote allowances**, **housing/relocation stipends**, and **regulated overtime pay** for extra instructional duties (Kim, 2022; OECD, 2023). Strong **career ladders** and continuous professional development are embedded within civil-service protections, ensuring both performance and welfare. Korea demonstrates a balanced application of economic and social protection levers.

3. Japan.

Under prefectural governance, Japan maintains stable **salary progression** schemes with **special duty allowances** for extracurricular and homeroom responsibilities (MEXT, 2022). Mandatory **kenshū** (in-service training) and structured **induction programs** for beginning teachers ensure professional continuity. Japan also enforces statutory limits on overtime and provides insurance coverage through the Japan Mutual Aid Association of Public School Teachers.

4. Singapore.

Singapore's Ministry of Education links **base salaries**, **annual performance bonuses**, and **posting incentives** to clearly defined career tracks within the **Teacher Growth Model** (MOE, 2021). Beginning teachers undergo a formal **induction and mentoring** process, supported by the National Institute of Education (NIE). Extensive **medical and social protection benefits** supplement its financially attractive system, aligning incentives with professional growth.

2.2.3 The Six Policy Levers: Operational Definitions

Table 1

The Six Policy Levers: Operational Definitions

Lever	Purpose	Minimum Codification Standard	Framework References
1. Compensation	Ensure market competitiveness and long-term retention.	Transparent salary scales with predictable progression.	OECD (2020); SABER-Teachers; DfE (2023).
2. Bonuses	Motivate performance or service in high-need areas.	Written criteria for eligibility and renewal; evaluation of impact.	OECD (2020); SABER-Teachers; MOE Singapore (2021).
3. Relocation Supports	Offset moving and settlement costs for priority area deployment.	Written criteria for eligibility and renewal; evaluation of impact.	OECD (2020); SABER-Teachers; MOE Singapore (2021).
4. Workload Pay	Compensate teaching beyond standard hours.	Codified base load and per-period overtime rules.	OECD (2023); Japan MEXT (2022).
5. Insurance & Protections	Safeguard health, income continuity, and safety.	Statutory coverage and clear claims procedures.	UNESCO (2023); OECD (2022).
6. Onboarding / Induction	Accelerate adaptation and professional integration.	Structured mentoring, reduced load, documented evaluation.	OECD (2020); UNESCO (2023); DfE (2021).

These six levers represent a **shared operational vocabulary** across frameworks and countries. Each lever was coded according to its **existence**, **specificity**, and **enforceability**, forming the empirical foundation for the TFETP comparative analysis.

2.2.4 Analytical Implications

Cross-framework synthesis suggests that high-performing systems translate broad policy commitments into *codified, budgeted, and monitored* mechanisms. Effective recruitment and retention depend on the **clarity of entitlement, transparency of allocation, and integration with professional development**. Where such levers are absent or discretionary, teacher policy coherence weakens—leading to fragmented incentives and uneven retention outcomes.

2.3 Policy Portability and Implementation Science

“Policy portability” is introduced here as a conceptual innovation that extends the classic notion of *policy transfer* (Dolowitz & Marsh, 2000) into an implementation-oriented frame. Whereas traditional policy transfer research focuses on *what* elements move across contexts, portability asks *under what administrative and fiscal conditions* a given policy can be adopted, adapted, or scaled without structural distortion. In this study, portability refers to the degree to which a recruitment or retention mechanism—such as salary progression, relocation allowances, or induction systems—can be feasibly implemented in another jurisdiction with minimal legal or administrative redesign.

Building on Dolowitz and Marsh’s (2000) typology of policy transfer (voluntary vs. coercive; lesson-drawing vs. emulation), portability emphasizes *feasibility conditions*:

1. **Legal feasibility**—alignment with existing civil-service and labor regulations;
2. **Fiscal feasibility**—predictable budgeting and cost sustainability;
3. **Administrative feasibility**—clarity of procedures, documentation, and accountability structures.

Policies high in portability thus display **clarity, codification, and modularity**, meaning they can be extracted from their originating context and embedded within a new one without loss of function. For example, Singapore’s structured *Beginning Teachers’ Program* or England’s *Early Career Framework* demonstrate portable design because their eligibility, duration, and

mentor ratios are fully specified and budgeted, allowing other systems to replicate the model with limited adaptation.

LeTendre and Akiba (2011) further advance this logic through cross-national analyses of teacher policy, showing that the **transferability of teacher career and compensation structures depends less on cultural similarity than on institutional compatibility**—particularly in how nations align fiscal policy, bureaucratic authority, and professional standards. Portability, in this sense, bridges comparative policy analysis with implementation science, translating international guidance (e.g., OECD, UNESCO, SABER) into *codifiable, auditable, and financeable* mechanisms that can survive the transition from document to practice.

In operational terms, this study rates each TFETP provision not only for *alignment* (High/Partial/Low) but also for *portability*—defined as the minimal set of **legal, fiscal, and administrative preconditions** necessary for cross-jurisdictional adoption. This dual coding allows for a more nuanced understanding of why some recruitment levers travel effectively across systems while others remain context-bound.

2.4 Identified Gaps

Despite the growing volume of international research on teacher recruitment and retention, significant gaps persist in how global frameworks are translated into actionable, codified policy mechanisms.

First, **few studies operationalize international guidance (e.g., OECD, UNESCO, World Bank) into clause-level or administrative instruments**. Existing analyses often remain at the declarative or conceptual level, describing policy “pillars” rather than mapping them onto actual program manuals, contract terms, or legal clauses. As a result, there is limited understanding of how guidance becomes embedded within real-world policy architecture.

Second, **mechanism-level and desk-based comparative analyses remain scarce**. Cross-national comparisons of teacher policy frequently focus on macro indicators (e.g., salary

ratios, attrition rates) or survey perceptions (e.g., TALIS), but rarely examine *the internal logic of implementation tools*—the specific rules, entitlements, and fiscal instruments that make teacher recruitment policies operable (LeTendre & Akiba, 2011; OECD, 2023). This study responds to that gap by employing a document-analytic approach that codes and evaluates explicit provisions within the TFETP and benchmarks them against codified standards from leading systems.

Finally, **the intersection of policy portability and implementation science remains under-theorized**. While the literature increasingly recognizes the need for evidence-based adaptation, few frameworks offer structured ways to assess *transfer readiness*—the degree to which an innovation can be imported without undermining its fiscal or administrative coherence (Fixsen et al., 2009). The present analysis contributes to this emerging dialogue by developing a cross-referenced portability matrix that connects **global guidance**, **national implementation capacity**, and **codification clarity**—a necessary step toward actionable comparative teacher policy design.

3. Methodology

3.1 Research Design

This study employs a **desk-based comparative policy analysis** to examine how Taiwan's Foreign English Teacher Program (TFETP) codifies recruitment and retention instruments relative to international guidance. Desk-based policy analysis emphasizes the systematic review of publicly available documentary evidence rather than field-collected data (Bowen, 2009). This approach enables transparent tracing of how policy instruments are articulated, embedded, and operationalized through formal documents (Dunn, 2018).

The analytic logic follows an **implementation-oriented alignment framework**, in which each TFETP clause or provision is coded against global teacher-policy benchmarks. Rather than focusing solely on normative adequacy, the analysis interrogates how provisions are designed for **operational feasibility** within existing administrative and fiscal structures. Alignment coding therefore combines content analysis (Krippendorff, 2019) with

implementation science perspectives (Fixsen et al., 2005), emphasizing *how* international recommendations are rendered actionable in program design. Each provision is coded across six pre-specified policy dimensions and evaluated for both *alignment* and *portability* to other jurisdictions.

3.2 Data Sources

The document corpus comprises primary TFETP policy texts and international reference frameworks. TFETP sources include:

1. Ministry of Education (MOE) Foreign English Teacher Program Contract Template (2023 edition).
2. TFETP Teacher and Assistant Manual (MOE, 2023).
3. MOE circulars, recruitment guidelines, and related administrative instructions (2019–2024).
4. Official TFETP website content and downloadable forms (<https://tfetp.epa.moe.gov.tw>).
5. Press releases and public statements issued by the MOE and Executive Yuan concerning program expansion or revisions.

These sources capture the formal and operational layers of the program—contractual obligations, remuneration structures, and administrative procedures.

International comparators are drawn from **multilateral frameworks and reports**, including:

- OECD Teacher Policy Framework (OECD, 2020).
- UNESCO Teacher Task Force for Education 2030 Annual Report (UNESCO, 2023).
- World Bank SABER-Teachers Policy Goals and Framework (Vegas et al., 2013).

- *Comparative Teacher Policy Reviews* from the United Kingdom, Korea, Japan, and Singapore.

Collectively, these documents provide normative guidance on compensation, career structures, working conditions, and teacher mobility, offering a global reference point for benchmarking TFETP provisions.

3.3 Coding Dimensions

All TFETP provisions were classified under six **policy dimensions**, derived inductively from convergence among OECD, UNESCO, and World Bank frameworks:

1. **Compensation Structure and Progression** – salary levels, stepwise increments, and parity with domestic teacher scales.
2. **Performance-Contingent Bonuses** – incentives linked to evaluation outcomes, contract renewal, or student performance.
3. **Relocation and Settlement Supports** – travel allowances, housing stipends, and family accompaniment policies.
4. **Workload Remuneration** – pay adjustments for overtime, co-teaching, extracurricular duties, and instructional contact hours beyond baseline expectations.
5. **Social Insurance and Worker Protections** – access to health, labor, and pension coverage; workplace safety and grievance procedures.
6. **Onboarding and Domestic Transport Assistance** – orientation sessions, airport pickup, school-level induction, and local transport subsidies.

Each dimension was operationalized as a *coding category* for line-by-line extraction. Provisions were cross-checked for clarity, enforceability, and congruence with international norms. The resulting matrix thus represents both structural (contractual) and procedural (implementation) facets of TFETP policy design.

3.4 Alignment and Portability Rubrics

Two rubrics guided the analytic evaluation. The first assesses **alignment** between TFETP provisions and international guidance on a **three-point scale**:

Table 2

policy portability rubric

Level	Description
High Alignment	Provision explicitly matches or exceeds international recommendations, demonstrating clear operational translation.
Partial Alignment	Provision references the concept but lacks full operational detail, clarity, or enforceability.
Low Alignment	Provision diverges from, omits, or contradicts international guidance.

The second rubric evaluates **policy portability**, defined as the degree to which a TFETP mechanism could be feasibly adapted elsewhere. Portability is appraised across three *implementation preconditions*:

- 1. Legal Preconditions** – statutory authority or regulatory flexibility necessary for adoption (e.g., employment classification, visa rules).
- 2. Fiscal Preconditions** – budgetary commitments or cost-sharing feasibility for comparable jurisdictions.
- 3. Administrative Preconditions** – institutional capacity for recruitment, supervision, and inter-agency coordination.

These criteria derive from *policy transfer* literature emphasizing that successful adaptation depends on contextual compatibility rather than mere imitation (Dolowitz & Marsh, 2000; LeTendre & Akiba, 2011).

3.5 Reliability and Validity

Methodological rigor was ensured through **dual-pass intra-rater reliability checking**. The same researcher independently re-coded the entire corpus after a two-week interval, comparing first- and second-round results. Minor discrepancies (<10%) were reconciled through memoing and adjudication logs. This process enhances stability of interpretive judgment and mitigates coder drift (Miles et al., 2020).

Triangulation further strengthened validity. Alignment ratings were cross-verified against OECD and domestic MOE documentation to confirm consistency in interpretation. For instance, the OECD *Teacher Policy Framework* (2020) was used as the normative benchmark for remuneration and workload clauses, while MOE press releases served as contextual validators for current practice. Triangulation across organizational sources ensures construct validity by linking document content to both global norms and local policy reality.

Additionally, **analytic transparency** was maintained through a full audit trail of coding sheets, versioned memos, and reference matrices. This auditability permits replication and independent verification of findings—critical in desk-based comparative policy research (Bowen, 2009).

3.6 Limitations

Three methodological limitations are acknowledged. First, TFETP’s internal performance data, such as teacher retention rates or satisfaction surveys, remain confidential; thus, the analysis is restricted to publicly available texts. Second, the absence of primary interview or observational data limits the capacity to assess *enacted* implementation. However, for the study’s purpose—**policy benchmarking**—a document-centered design is both appropriate and proportionate. Comparative policy analysis relies on the examination of codified instruments as a proxy for state intent and capacity (Dolowitz & Marsh, 2000).

Third, the analysis necessarily reflects the status of TFETP documentation as of early 2025; subsequent amendments may alter specific clauses. Nevertheless, the desk-based approach provides a robust, transparent, and replicable means to gauge alignment and portability, offering

a foundation for future mixed-methods extensions incorporating practitioner perspectives or fiscal modeling.

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Would you like me to draft **Section 1.2 (Rationale and Purpose of the Study)** next—so it connects logically to this section and follows journal-submission conventions (e.g., last paragraph of 1.1 ending → research gap and study purpose)?